

# How Earning Money Works on AISH and ADAP

*What you keep, what comes off, and why working is still worth it. Verified against the AISH policy manual.*

A lot of people are afraid that earning money will cost them their benefit. Here is how it works, in plain numbers, so you can decide with facts.

## 1. The part you keep in full

Every month, a set amount of what you earn is fully yours. It does not touch your benefit at all. That amount depends on your situation:

| Your situation                               | Fully yours each month |
|----------------------------------------------|------------------------|
| On AISH, single                              | \$350                  |
| On ADAP, single                              | \$700                  |
| On ADAP, with dependents                     | \$1,100                |
| Cohabiting partner of an AISH or ADAP client | \$1,500                |

## 2. What happens above that, and here the two programs are very different

**On AISH:** every dollar you earn above \$350 comes off your benefit, dollar for dollar. That is a hard line, a cliff.

**On ADAP:** above your exempt amount, your benefit is reduced gradually, not all at once. You keep part of every dollar you earn, and the reduction phases in slowly as your earnings rise, until the benefit eventually phases out at higher income. So on ADAP, earning more always leaves you with more in your pocket than not working. It is a slope, not a cliff.

### One real problem: they do not publish the rate

The government does not state the exact ADAP reduction rate anywhere in plain numbers. To see what your benefit would be at a given income, you have to use their online AISH and ADAP benefit estimator. So if you want your exact figure, run the estimator, and when your benefit is calculated, ask them in writing to show you the math.

## 3. A worked example

Say you are single on ADAP and you earn \$830 in a month. Your first \$700 is fully yours, untouched. Only the \$130 above the line is looked at, and on ADAP that \$130 is reduced gradually, so only a portion of it comes off your benefit, not the whole amount. You come out clearly ahead by working. Nobody takes your \$830, and nobody takes your whole benefit.

## 4. The habit that protects you

Report your earnings the way they ask. When your benefit is recalculated, ask them in writing to show exactly how the reduction was figured, and keep a copy. The rules are new, so if a number looks off, you can check it.

*Verified against the Assured Income for the Severely Handicapped policy manual (AISH and ADAP), Income Exemptions, updated July 2, 2026. The exempt amounts adjust over time, so confirm current figures and your own calculation with the program.*

### The Alberta Disability System Breakdown — Advocate

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